D.J. PARIS

THE MORTGAGE IS NOT THE REAL PAYMENT.

Owning this house adds $16,566 a year the mortgage never counted.

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$16,566. THAT'S WHAT A HOUSE COSTS EVERY YEAR AFTER THE MORTGAGE CHECK CLEARS.

Insurance, taxes, and upkeep. Not optional, not occasional.

03 / 05

THE MORTGAGE IS THE SMALLEST SURPRISE IN THE BUDGET.

Zillow and Thumbtack's report, published October 22, 2026: the typical homeowner pays $16,566 a year in costs the mortgage payment never includes, about $1,380 a month on top of it. Maintenance is the biggest piece at $11,171, property taxes add $3,129, and homeowners insurance, now $2,266, has climbed 54 percent over the last five years, the fastest-rising of the three. Zillow senior economist Kara Ng: "Long after they receive the keys, insurance, taxes and upkeep are recurring expenses to plan for."

RUN THIS BEFORE A BUYER WRITES AN OFFER:

1 **Price the full monthly number, not just the mortgage.**
Add roughly $1,380 to the lender's estimate before the buyer falls for the payment on the listing sheet.

2 **Pull a current insurance quote, not last year's rate.**
Premiums are up 54 percent in five years; a stale number undersells the real payment.

3 **Show the actual tax bill, not the MLS field's guess.**
A recent reassessment can move that number more than the mortgage rate will.

4 **Put a maintenance line in writing.**
$11,171 a year is the typical homeowner's biggest hidden cost; a buyer who sees it coming doesn't blame their agent later.

THE TAKEAWAY

THE BUYER WHO SEES THE WHOLE NUMBER TRUSTS THE AGENT WHO SHOWED IT TO THEM.

Show the carrying cost before the mortgage company does.

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